

INVESTIGATIVE DOSSIER • THE EARLY-STAGE RAINMAKERS

SEED_ROUND: THE VENTURE KINGPINS & EARLY-STAGE LAW FIRMS

The Individual Lead Partners & Law Firm Chairs Who Personally Structure Seed, Series A, B, and C Financings

CONFIDENTIAL INTELLIGENCE BRIEFING • PREPARED FOR EXECUTIVE LEADERSHIP • AUGUST 2026

THE EARLY-STAGE RAINMAKER THESIS:

While late-stage growth rounds are driven by private equity metrics and financial engineering, **Seed, Series A, and Series B rounds are driven by high-conviction individuals.** The lawyer who drafts the incorporation documents (Delaware C-Corp) and the VC partner who takes the first Board seat dictate the company's trajectory, cap table governance, and ultimate liquidity exit.

THE TOP 8 EARLY-STAGE VC PARTNERS (SEED TO SERIES C LEAD CHECKS)

LEAD PARTNER & FIRM	PREFERRED ROUND FOCUS	HISTORIC EARLY-STAGE WINS (SEED / A / B / C)	OUTSIDE LAW FIRM REPRESENTATION
Alfred Lin Sequoia Capital	Series A & Series B Lead	DoorDash (Led \$17M Series A; Board Member), Airbnb (Early Board Member), Reddit (Series B lead)	Wilson Sonsini (WSGR) & Cooley LLP
Peter Thiel Founders Fund	Seed, Series A & Series B	Stripe (Seed / Series B Lead), Scale AI (Series B/C Lead), Cognition AI (Series A Lead), Airbnb (Series C)	Orrick, Herrington & Sutcliffe & Cooley LLP
Vinod Khosla Khosla Ventures	Seed & Series A Lead	OpenAI (First \$50M check in 2019), GitLab (Series A Lead; Board Member), Instacart (Seed/A), DoorDash (Series A)	Wilson Sonsini (WSGR)
Josh Kushner Thrive Capital	Series B, C & Growth	Stripe (Series C Lead; Board Member), OpenAI (\$6.6B Lead check), Scale AI (Series F), Sierra AI	Paul, Weiss, Rifkind, Wharton & Garrison & Cooley LLP
Nat Friedman & Daniel Gross NFDG / AI Grant	Seed & Series A (Compute + Cash)	Perplexity AI (Seed / Series A), Cursor (Seed / Series A), Cognition (Seed), ElevenLabs (Series A), Suno , Pika	Gunderson Dettmer (Trevor Snider) & Cooley
Elad Gil Solo Capitalist / Super-Angel	Seed & Series A Lead	Perplexity AI (Seed Lead), Harvey AI (Series B), Cognition (Seed), Stripe (Series A), Cursor , Runway	Gunderson Dettmer & Cooley LLP
Martin Casado & Marc Andreessen Andreessen Horowitz (a16z)	Seed, Series A & B	Airbnb (Series B Lead), Coinbase (Series B Lead), ElevenLabs (Series A), Mistral AI (Series A), Cursor , SSI	Gunderson Dettmer & Cooley LLP
Dan Levine & Mike Volpi Accel & Index Ventures	Seed, Series A & B	Scale AI (Dan Levine led Seed; Mike Volpi led Series A), Cursor , Augment Code , DeepL , Mistral	Cooley LLP (Rachel Proffitt) & WSGR

THE TOP 4 EARLY-STAGE LAW FIRMS STRUCTURING SEED THROUGH SERIES C

LAW FIRM	LEAD PARTNERS	EARLY-STAGE PLATFORM & INSTRUMENTS	NOTABLE SEED-TO-SERIES C FORMATIONS
Cooley LLP cooley.com	Rachel Proffitt, Peter Werner, Charlie Kim, David Peinsipp	Cooley GO (Standard Series A / NVCA documents, SAFEs, equity incentive pools)	OpenAI, Scale AI, Reddit, Perplexity AI, Segment, Augment Code, Figure AI
Wilson Sonsini (WSGR) wsgr.com	Steven Bochner, Tony Jeffries, Mark Baudler, Craig Sherman	WSGR Startup Platform (Automated Delaware incorporation, 83(b) tax elections)	DoorDash, Anthropic, Instacart, Dropbox, PlanGrid, Khosla Ventures funds
Gunderson Dettmer gunder.com	Trevor Snider, Brian Patterson, Ivan Gaviria	Gunderson Launch (Venture fund formation, SPVs, seed-to-scale term sheets)	Cursor (Anysphere), Cognition AI (Devin), ElevenLabs, Suno, Pika, NFDG, a16z
Fenwick & West LLP fenwick.com	Mark Stevens, Gordon Davidson, David Bell	Fenwick Venture Desk (Early corporate governance, tech IP assignment)	Airbnb, Coinbase, Stripe, Twitch (Justin.tv), Amplitude, PagerDuty

